Mikeitz 5784

In the first half of פרשת מקץ, we have, in exquisite detail, the story of פרעה's dreams. It's repeated again, and יוסף repeats it one more time as he interprets it. The details are פסוק after פסוק after פסוק after פסוק. And as we know, there are many great הלכות in the תורה that we learn from only רמזים, from a letter here and a letter there. Yet one of the details in this story - what might seem to be one of the least important features - is the number of times the פסוקים recount פרעה speaking to יוסף. I count five:

1. When they pull יוסף out of the בור, in פרק מא פסוק טו, it says, וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף חֲלוֹם חָלַמְתִּי.
2. פסוק יז: וַיְדַבֵּר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף בַּחֲלֹמִי הִנְנִי עֹמֵד עַל שְׂפַת הַיְאֹר.
3. After יוסף explains the dream, in פסוק לט: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אַחֲרֵי הוֹדִיעַ אֱלֹהִים אוֹתְךָ אֶת כָּל זֹאת אֵין נָבוֹן וְחָכָם כָּמוֹךָ.
4. Two פסוקים later, פסוק מא: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף רְאֵה נָתַתִּי אֹתְךָ עַל כָּל אֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם.
5. פסוק מד: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אֲנִי פַּרְעֹה וּבִלְעָדֶיךָ לֹא יָרִים אִישׁ אֶת יָדוֹ.

Notice the difference in wording among these five פסוקים. Four out of the five start with וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה, but one of them, number two, starts with וַיְדַבֵּר פַּרְעֹה. We all know that אמירה is a לשון רכה and דיבור is a לשון קשה. Why does פסוק יז use a לשון of וידבר פרעה?

Let's go back and start from the beginning. פרעה says to יוסף, "I dreamt a dream" (ויאמר פרעה, the first one). He continues, "Nobody can explain it to me, but I heard you can interpret dreams." What does יוסף answer him? וַיַּעַן יוֹסֵף אֶת פַּרְעֹה לֵאמֹר בִּלְעָדַי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲנֶה אֶת שְׁלוֹם פַּרְעֹה. Immediately afterward, פרעה switches to וידבר פרעה. Why does פרעה change from ויאמר to וידבר? Something upset him. What was it?

The בית הלוי points out that פרעה tried to trick יוסף by using a phrase in his description of the dream that wasn't in the original dream. In פסוק יט, he says, וְהִנֵּה שֶׁבַע פָּרוֹת אֲחֵרוֹת עֹלוֹת אַחֲרֵיהֶן דַּלּוֹת וְרָעוֹת תֹּאַר מְאֹד וְרַקּוֹת בָּשָׂר. The word דַּלּוֹת wasn't in the original description as the תורה described it. Why would פרעה do that? He's going out of his beanbags trying to get the answer, why is he going out of his way to trick יוסף?

The answer is that יוסף did something which was unconscionable in פרעה's mind and unconscionable in our world today. יוסף said, "Hashem is in charge." Nobody wants to hear that. Not one גוי wants to hear that. Unfortunately, many of us don't want to hear it either. But it's the truth: Hashem is in charge. וַיַּעַן יוֹסֵף אֶת פַּרְעֹה לֵאמֹר בִּלְעָדַי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲנֶה אֶת שְׁלוֹם פַּרְעֹה - I don't do anything, it all comes from Hashem, אין עוד מלבדו. This upset פרעה so much that he switched his language to וידבר, a harsher tone. Ultimately, once פרעה realized that יוסף's interpretation was correct, he returned to ויאמר. (All of the mefarshim ask the question: how did פרעה know that יוסף's interpretation was correct? The easiest explanation is that פרעה had originally dreamt the interpretation and forgotten it, and יוסף simply reminded him. Alternatively, it's just as straightforward to say that פרעה recognized the truth of יוסף's interpretation because it was so obvious, so in tune with what he had seen and experienced in his dream).

In פסוק לט: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אַחֲרֵי הוֹדִיעַ אֱלֹהִים אוֹתְךָ אֶת כָּל זֹאת אֵין נָבוֹן וְחָכָם כָּמוֹךָ - פרעה had to admit that יוסף's claim - that all interpretations come from Hashem - was correct. This wasn't easy for him, but that is our job: to make a kiddush Hashem, to show the world that everything comes from Hashem. We have to constantly have the שם השם שגור בפינו. That's our job: to make a kiddush Hashem. This one little שינוי in the לשון - how the פסוק changes from ויאמר to וידבר - drives this lesson home. I'm glad I once intuited this idea. It's fascinating to look at these לשונות and see what's right there beneath the surface, hiding, waiting to teach us a tremendous מוסר השכל. Let's take this lesson and use it to become better people.

https://youtu.be/xUnsUm3qK2Y